

Decision Maker

In this comparison test, we've omitted products we reviewed in the last comparison; most of those products are still available in the market, though. Given the choice, choosing the right phone for the right kind of application can be confusing.

MUSIC PHONES

Entry Level

At the entry level, nothing beats Sony Ericsson's Walkman phones—the W200i is where it starts from, but if you can stretch your budget by a couple of thousand, we recommend the W610i or W810i. Both these phones have excellent music quality, and are available for under Rs 10,000.

Mid-range

Here you have options from both Nokia as well as Sony Ericsson. The SE W850i and W660i have excellent audio quality, and come with good earphones. Nokia N73 Music Edition and the XpressMusic 5160 and 5130 have good music players too. Most of these phones fall in the Rs 10,000-15,000 price bracket. The Sony Ericsson phones win here for their excellent sound.

The Best

Nokia's N95, the Apple iPhone and the Sony Ericsson W910i are your best bets here. There isn't much difference in music quality between the N95 and W910i. While the N95 is bulky, the W910i is light and slim—it also has the "shake" controls and SenseMe technologies. The N95 is a more complete package, so we recommend that. The iPhone offers a great user experience, but the sound quality can't match the other two—especially on the bundled earphones.

CAMERA PHONES

Entry Level

Here, the Cybershot phones from Sony Ericsson are your best option. The SE K550i is a superb entry level camera phone, which also has a good music player and FM radio. The trusted K750i is still a worthy phone here. The Nokia N70 also has a comparable camera, but it's an old phone and not everyone might like to own it.

Mid-range

The Sony Ericsson K810i is an excellent 3.2 megapixel camera phone, and at Rs 15,000, is quite a package. The K790i—the first 3.2 megapixel phone in the market—is now available for Rs 11,000, and makes for terrific value. Nokia fans can get similar camera quality in the Nokia N73 and N73 ME. The camera on the XpressMusic Nokia 5160 is also in the same league.

Top Of The Line

The Nokia N95 and N82 have 5 megapixel cameras, and they deliver crisp photographs in all conditions—with a few tweaks in settings. Both have extensive in-camera controls, and also offer a TV out cable. If the N95 is too expensive for you, go for the N82. The Sony Ericsson K850i delivers good photographs, but there are few issues—photographs tend to under-expose when the flash is used; hopefully, a firmware upgrade will fix this.

BUSINESS PHONES

Entry Level

The Nokia E51. Nothing beats this newcomer—3G, WiFi, Bluetooth, IR, USB—you're always connected in every possible way. A good screen, decent multimedia features and a sweet price of Rs 13,000 gives it an edge over every other phone in this category.

Mid-range

The ASUS P526, the Motorola Q, the ASUS M530w, the Nokia E61i and Sony Ericsson P1i are few of the better options here. Nokia's E61i has been our favourite. It is feature-laden, delivers good performance and is priced reasonably—it's still difficult for us to recommend something else. However, if you want a phone with a touchscreen, then the ASUS P526 and Sony Ericsson P1i are your best bets.

High-end

The Blackberry platform is hard to beat when it comes to core business-oriented features. The Curve 8300 and 8830 World Edition are the best, but if you care for better multimedia options, we suggest the Nokia E90—it's sturdy and powerful. The Blackberry Pearl 8120 is a great phone if you don't want to carry a bulky business phone. If you want more PDA features—and a touchscreen to boot—you should look at the ASUS P750.

PHONES TO FLAUNT

The Apple iPhone! No one has it, and that's good enough reason to buy it. That apart, the iPhone is a gadget in its own class, and will get you noticed wherever you go.

The Motorola RAZR V2 is the phone to have if you want something that's a little more, well, legal. The pearl-grey finish, large LCDs and intricate detailing makes the phone stand out from the crowd. The new RAZR is not all show—it has a lot of practical features and a completely revised user interface too. It's also much cheaper than the iPhone. The Blackberry Pearl 8120 is another classy-looking phone, but only for serious businessmen on the move. ■

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